

SHADES OF LIFE... *In a Cannibal Time* is a window into Kishore's way of expressing as well as documenting performing arts





Photographs by DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Poet, publisher (Seagull Books), photographer, and theatre person Naveen Kishore, 70, wears several hats. It's his photography hat that is currently on display at Emami Art in the Kolkata Centre for Creativity. The exhibition *In A Cannibal Time* is in collaboration with Chatterjee & Lal (who had taken Kishore's *Performing the Goddess* to the Cincinnati Art Museum) and is showing at the gallery till June 25. It includes four series: *Performing the Goddess*, *The Green Room of the Goddess*, *The Epic and the Elusive*, and *In a Cannibal Time*.

According to Kishore, his photographs are 'happy accidents'. This is particularly true for the photographs in *The Epic and the Elusive*. They were shot over 20 years ago as part of a series for Seagull Theatre Quarterly's issue on theatre in Manipur. "Most of them were experimental takes on Greek classics like Antigone, etc," says Kishore, explaining the 'epic' referred to in the series. What remains 'elusive' are blurred smoke-like figures captured "in a certain kind of motion" in the black and white series. "[The act of capturing the actors in motion] was the only thing I was certain of. Since I shoot analogue—it is all chance. I'm capturing her [points out an actor in a picture] in movement while everything else is static. And it resulted in these happy accidents—where one person looks like they are disappearing into smoke, while another looks straight at you giving it a kind of documentary aspect," he explains.

Three of the four series by Naveen Kishore the exhibition showcases dwell on the feminine

As the owner of the independent publishing house Seagull Books, Kishore refers to his bookmaking work as "midwifery", but his photography (like his poetry) is a more direct expression. In the case of photography, he says, "I'm engaging with the possibility of giving 'vocabulary' to that which I witness."

In the ongoing exhibition, what has attracted the most attention are the two 'Goddess' series: *Performing the Goddess* and *The Green Room of the Goddess*. Photographs from both are placed side by side deliberately by Seagull Books' chief editor and graphic designer Sunandini Banerjee. While *Performing the Goddess* studies jatra actor Chapal Bhaduri getting out of the costume of the goddess Sitala, shedding the layers that make the man a woman and a goddess, *The Green Room of the Goddess* features idols of Kali in various stages of adorning and enrobing. Kali is watched "almost voyeuristically as if caught unawares, almost unguarded." "Perhaps later, when the clay becomes the Goddess, the gaze would change into a more direct one," ponders Kishore. The contrast between the two series—where one sheds the myth of